

WATER- AND AIR-COOLED MACHINE-GUNS

The air-cooled machine-guns of World War II marked a shift away from the water-cooled models of World War I, although a notable exception was the tried-and-tested Vickers. Another trend was the twin development of the light machine-gun, with examples such as the Bren and the Breda, and the heavy machine-gun, exemplified by the Degtyarev DShK1938 and the Browning M2 HB. The key technological development came from Germany, however, with the introduction of the MG34. The first general-purpose machine-gun, it combined the sustained-fire role of the heavy or medium machine-gun with the portability of the light machine-gun.

► BROWNING M1919

Date 1919

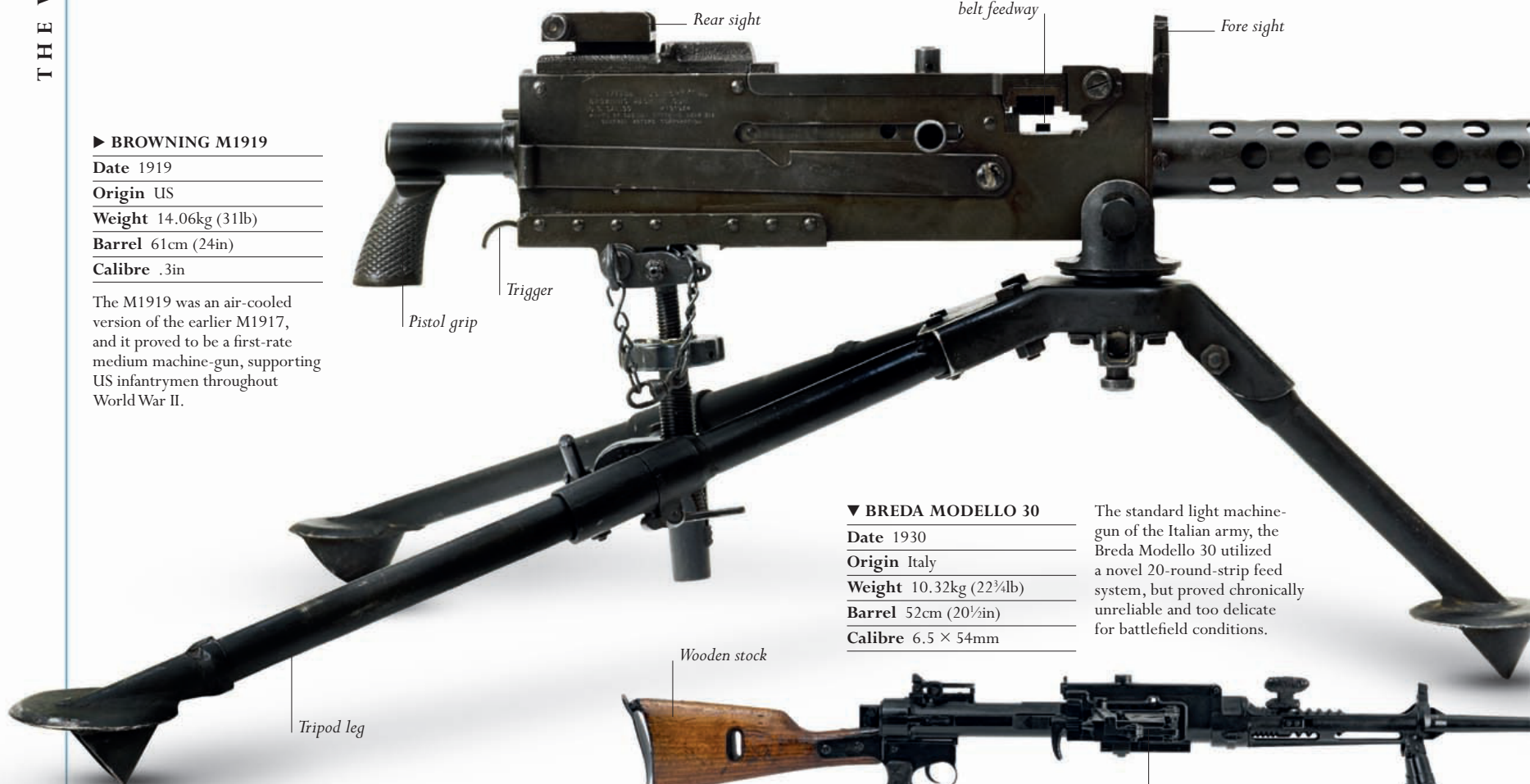
Origin US

Weight 14.06kg (31lb)

Barrel 61cm (24in)

Calibre .3in

The M1919 was an air-cooled version of the earlier M1917, and it proved to be a first-rate medium machine-gun, supporting US infantrymen throughout World War II.



► VICKERS MK I

Date 1912

Origin UK

Weight 18.1kg (40lb)

Barrel 72.1cm (28½in)

Calibre .303in

Employed in both world wars, the water-cooled Vickers was an extremely reliable medium machine-gun, and, when firing the Mk 8Z bullet, was capable of a range of up to 4.1km (2.54 miles).



▼ BREDA MODELLO 30

Date 1930

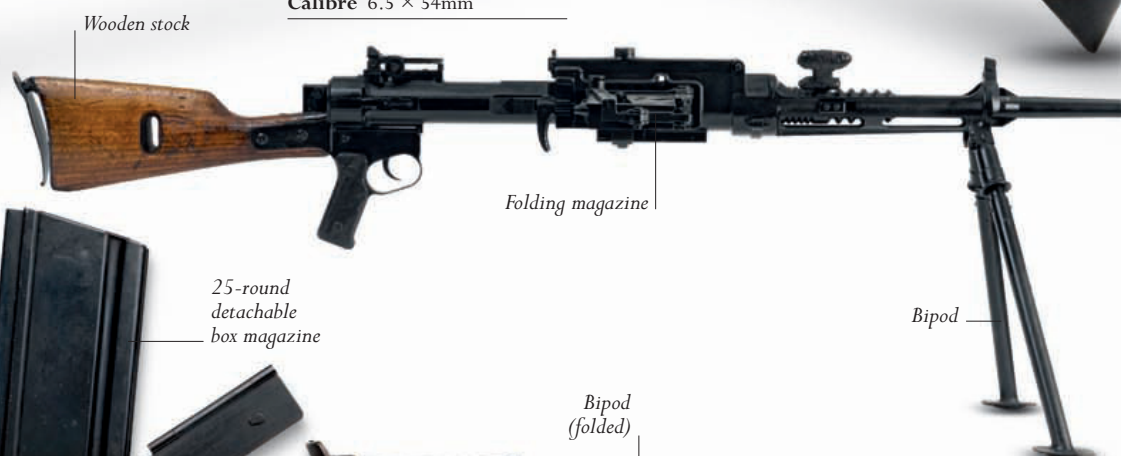
Origin Italy

Weight 10.32kg (22¾lb)

Barrel 52cm (20½in)

Calibre 6.5 × 54mm

The standard light machine-gun of the Italian army, the Breda Modello 30 utilized a novel 20-round-strip feed system, but proved chronically unreliable and too delicate for battlefield conditions.



▼ FM MODEL 1924/29

Date 1930s

Origin France

Weight 8.93kg (19½lb)

Barrel 50cm (20in)

Calibre 7.5 × 57mm

With a firing mechanism based on that of the Browning BAR, the FM M1924/29 suffered from cartridge problems, which were resolved by the time it became the French army's standard light machine-gun in World War II.

